

DEMOCRATIC SANCTIONS AND THE SELECTIVE TARGETING OF
AUTHORITARIAN REGIMES
REPLICATION AND EXTENSION PRESENTATION

Jakob Lütkeemeier

M.Sc. Applied Social Data Science
Trinity College Dublin

Applied Statistical Analysis II

WHY ARE SOME DICTATORS SANCTIONED AND OTHERS SPARED?

- ▶ Democratic sanctions are meant to punish authoritarian backsliding.
- ▶ Yet many authoritarian regimes violate democratic norms without being sanctioned.
- ▶ Others are sanctioned quickly after visible political shocks.

Core puzzle

Sanctions are not simply a reaction to repression. They are **selective political choices**.

THE PAPER'S ANSWER

A THREE-PART FRAMEWORK

Pressure to sanction

- ▶ Coups
- ▶ Controversial elections

Target vulnerability

- ▶ Weaker regimes
- ▶ Less resilient targets

Sender costs

- ▶ Economic exposure
- ▶ Political alignment

Main Hypothesis

Weaker triggers create more room for strategic discretion.

WHAT EXACTLY I REPLICATED

Design

- ▶ Authoritarian country-years, 1990–2010.
- ▶ Outcome: **democratic sanction onset** (binary).
- ▶ Main estimator: **clustered logit** for binary onset

Replicated outputs

- ▶ Table I
- ▶ Table II
- ▶ Table III
- ▶ Figure 2

What is a *clustered logit model*?

Like normal logit, a clustered logit models the probability of a binary outcome. The difference is that it adjusts the standard errors because repeated observations from the same country are likely correlated.

REPLICATION RESULT

DRAMATIC TRIGGERS MATTER MOST

- ▶ The replication recovers the paper's **trigger hierarchy**.
- ▶ **Coups** sharply increase sanction likelihood.
- ▶ **Controversial elections** also matter, but less strongly.
- ▶ Static democratic weakness is less important than visible political shocks.

Interpretation

Sanctions respond most strongly to events that are politically visible and difficult to ignore.

Table I: trigger coefficients

	Western	EU	US
Coup	5.127***	3.765***	4.947***
Democracy score	-0.056	-0.081	-0.116
Controversial election	2.584***	2.620***	2.275***

Table II: predicted probabilities

	Western	EU	US
Baseline	0.007	0.007	0.004
Coup	0.519	0.232	0.346
Controversial election	0.074	0.084	0.032

REPLICATION RESULT

SANCTIONS ARE SELECTIVE, NOT AUTOMATIC

- ▶ Sanctions are not explained by triggers alone.
- ▶ **Target vulnerability** matters: higher **inflation** is associated with higher sanction odds.
- ▶ **Sender costs** matter: politically closer regimes and regimes with higher **FDI** are less likely to be sanctioned.

Table III: selective-targeting coefficients

	Western
Coup	5.128***
Controversial election	2.909***
Inflation ($t - 1$)	0.022**
FDI inflows ($t - 1$)	-0.046*
Political closeness to West ($t - 1$)	-4.413**

Interpretation

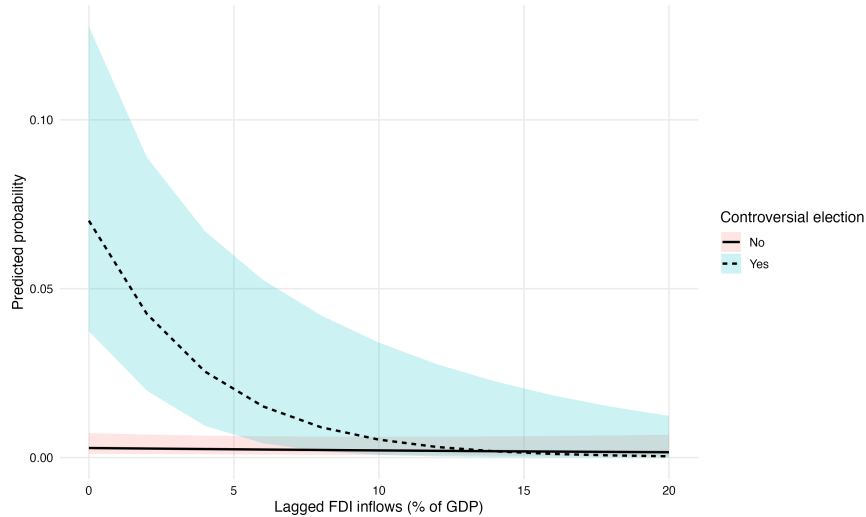
Even when democratic violations occur, sanctions depend on both **target vulnerability** and **sender costs**.

REPLICATION RESULTS

WHEN SENDER COSTS MATTER MOST

Controversial election × FDI

Table III shows that **sender costs** matter on average. Figure 2 shows *when* one sender-cost variable—**FDI**—matters most: after **controversial elections**.



MY EXTENSION

DOES GEOPOLITICAL ALIGNMENT ALSO SHIELD REGIMES?

Extension question

If economic exposure can shield regimes after weaker triggers, can **political alignment** do the same?

Motivation

- ▶ The paper already shows that political closeness matters overall.
- ▶ Figure 2 suggests discretion is greatest after controversial elections.
- ▶ The natural next step is to test whether political alignment matters *especially there*.

Setup

- ▶ Controversial Election $\times$ High Political Closeness
- ▶ High Closeness = top quartile of UN voting similarity.
- ▶ Coded as a dummy: 1 = top quartile, 0 = lower three quartiles.

EXTENSION RESULT

THE PATTERN IS THERE, BUT CAUTIOUSLY

- ▶ Descriptively, controversial elections are followed by **fewer sanctions** among highly aligned regimes.
- ▶ The interaction term is **negative**, matching the theoretical expectation.
- ▶ The direction is substantively interesting, but the evidence is not strong enough to present as decisive.

Verdict

Theory-consistent and informative, but inferentially uncertain.

Extension model: interaction coefficients

	Baseline	Interaction
Controversial election	2.817***	3.123***
High political closeness (top quartile)	−1.295+	−0.590
Controversial election × high political closeness		−1.784

Observed sanction rates by political closeness

Political closeness	N	Sanctions	Rate
Lower 3 quartiles	59	10	0.169
Top quartile	44	1	0.023

EXTENSION ROBUSTNESS CHECKS

- ▶ I varied the threshold used to define **high political closeness**.
- ▶ The interaction remained **negative** under nearby one-year threshold choices.
- ▶ With a **two-year lag** of political closeness, the interaction weakened and lost directional consistency.
- ▶ Overall, the extension is **plausible but specification-sensitive**.

Takeaway

The robustness checks support a cautious reading: the extension is theory-consistent and informative, but not decisive.

TAKEAWAY

STRONG REPLICATION, MODEST EXTENSION

Replication

- ▶ Core findings are successfully recovered.
- ▶ Coups and controversial elections matter.
- ▶ Sender costs & target vulnerability remain central.

Extension

- ▶ Political alignment may also shield regimes.
- ▶ Most plausibly after weaker triggers.
- ▶ Evidence is suggestive, not definitive.

Final message

Democratic sanctions are **selective**: they respond to authoritarian violations, but also to the strategic costs faced by sanctioning states.